



Story Header



by SavantGuarde

Chapter Fifty-Six

• 5.56.1 • 5.56.2 •

The Last Firebrand

01



TITUS

A loud snap cracks through the cavern as crimson threads weave themselves into every wall, across the floors, and all atop the ceiling, wriggling like long neon earthworms delving into dirt.

I dodge before he drives his fist past my head. We strain at the pulse in our circuits when the threads as thick as ropes tighten until they're tenser than a bowstring, as if pulled by a master archer. They hum with such a deafening frequency that I can't hear what Ullrich says when he moves his mouth. The resonance pulses the air around the walls. We cover our ears in anguish, unable to fight, brought to our knees until the first thread snaps, and the inertia of time lurches for the both of us.

I fall back in a familiar chair. Before I can open my eyes, the recognition is instant: falling back on the teetering back-left leg until Sylvia shimmed it with one of her scrapped drawings.

That was second year.

My room is just as it was the first day I moved in: not a speck of dust, and I'm frozen there in the doorway with my father helping me lift the bed frame.

I have only seconds to dodge Ullrich when he comes for me. I grab for the cup of pencils on the Academy desk as I dive towards the window, but my hand slips through them, tipping them over as if I'm only made of wind. I stumble to the side and almost fall through the window— the force is enough to spiderweb the corner in the same place I remembered finding it — yet I pull myself up to confront Ullrich as he recovers.

"I can give you a better life than this. We can start over. You can have a real father," he says, swatting the cigarette from Clint's mouth as his hand passes through his head, coaxing it out my true father's lips to leave that burn in the carpet.

Made of whatever ethereal presence we're in, the force between us is real. I manage a blow against his chest with my fist and it staggers him, disappearing behind Age 16 Titus as he ever-so-slowly sets the frame on the floor. But Ullrich surprises me through the solid shape, punching me directly in the head.

I fall to the floor years later in under a second. Dawn freezes in the windowsill, and Sylvia sits at the edge of the bed as I'm turned away from her. Ullrich leaps over the bed and through that Titus' chest as I recoil against the wall, springing forward to get an advantage on him, blasting my knuckles into his jaw as the vision changes again.

We're in the courtyard of some grand estate, but it's not the Afterlife. Verdant vines span the walls of a castle older than everything in Blackwater. The world is green as far as my eyes can see. Two dark-haired children smile as they slash at each other with wooden swords, as finely-dressed royalty watch, and I recognize them from the painting.

Ullrich wipes his mouth. The blood is certainly real. "This was a hundred and sixty years before you were born. Nordhaven was our city, our birthright, and it was taken from us!"

"We don't have the right to change what happens. We'll never be satisfied if we allow ourselves to suffer forever," I tell him, but it only angers him further.

He uppercuts me in the stomach. I land on the kitchen table of my childhood home as the air parts my lungs. The musket blast is blinding, and I watch as the bullet collides with Valentina's skull all over again, erupting her thoughts across Romin's face as he recoils and makes his choice to die a martyr.

I roll off the table before Ullrich can use the knife he tried to grasp and dive out the window, passing so quickly through it that it doesn't have the force to shatter. Bullets fly from the Royal Guard like beads on a thousand strings, inching ever-so-slowly though the consequences of their trajectory are real.

I feel it graze me. White-hot pain sears my arm, and I trip over the steps of the entryway just as the house is set to explode.

My head collides with something fragile and wooden. The snow is cold. It's a mound of dirt far beyond the walls, and I can instantly recognize the house. Ullrich is standing over me, but he's far younger, and far more emotionally distraught.

"I buried you here a hundred and twelve times until it broke me," Ullrich says. His older face pops through his younger one. "This was the first time I lost all of you, one by one, when the extremists that destroyed Nordhaven finished their job on the last of us. We were so weak and defenseless."

I try to lift myself, but he grabs my clothes by the collar, throwing me against a tree in the wooded glen. Several lonely years flash past my eyes when my head collides with the bark, and I see Ullrich standing at the apex of the roof, ready to end his suffering until Khiras approaches from behind him, joined by a young girl.

"A secret kept from the other Gods. Essenced magic violating the rules of life itself," he said, "and your Sylvia must have taken that idea from her on one of your trips to the Reservoir."

Time flashes backwards to a time long before. A pocket of green christens the house with leafy trees. Ullrich stands beside himself. Young Ullrich stands on the porch, smiling, with a woman holding a dark-haired baby: my true mother.

"You're a cross-blood, Fletcher! You're a mask of both sides, and you were going to be my legacy," Ullrich says. "But no matter how hard I tried to save you, you would die at their hands. I hemorrhaged Essence just trying to keep you alive, when every time I returned you knew nothing of what I went through. Have you figured

it out yet, that Essence is the only thing we carry from those past lives? So many dead timelines. What does one unforgivable act weigh, in one unfortunate timeline, when it all of it will just disappear?"

We're in the coliseum beyond time. In one time I drive my sword through the back of Isla. Another time, I stab those cadets over and over and over until their bodies are unrecognizable, and when I lift my ethereal form from that pit where I almost lost my soul, I tell him. "It doesn't. Those timelines still live, and that price is far more than either one of us can afford." I try to grab the hilt of that Titus' blade, but he's far too intent with fury.

And then we reach a place that neither of us can recognize. Maybe it's a future from a lost time. Or maybe it's the dreams we wish for so strongly that they materialize.

Ullrich limps towards that beautiful vision. I can feel the heat from the sun on my skin as the trees shimmer with their glistening, jade leaves, and beneath the canopy, Ullrich's dead wife calls to him with the baby in her arms. In front of me, Clint and Moira are together. Ellie grins from ear-to-ear with the tender smile I thought she'd lost forever. Romin and Valentina are there, too, along with their families, and Sylvia stands in front of me with a wriggling bundle of blankets in her arms.

"We can get here, Fletcher. We can have it!"

I watch as Ellie runs toward me, calling my name, ready to spring for a tender hug so that I can swing her around and plant a kiss on her cheek. But someone else emerges from behind them: a different Ellie, the one I made my promise to, and I remember what she said before my final death.

I can feel the knife still in my belt, and I unsheathe it before she can reach me. I can see the tar left behind by her footsteps, sullyng the illusory dirt, and as my hands tighten around the blade I know is there though I can't see it, I drive one final thrust into the heart of the young girl as she cries out in astonished panic.



TITUS

The Heiress grasps her chest where the dagger protrudes from between her ribs. My sister's hot blood is on my hands. The threads retreat from the walls and I'm back in the cavern as Ullrich grasps longingly for that dying image.

Ellie collapses to the ground, choking on the blood that fills her lungs, but before I can cry for what I've done, I viciously rip the thread from my wrist, sealing my fate in this timeline alone.

Incredible power floods my circuits when the amulet finally reacts, absorbed wholly into my body, and when the white-hot flames cover my skin, I charge for Ullrich, tightening my hands around his neck as the Essence drains from his body.

He tries to struggle, but his strength is no match.

"You've betrayed your entire race. You decide in the intensity of this moment to accept their sacrifice. But when the intensity is gone and the guilt is all that remains, you will plead to go back. You will rue this choice!"

"Then it will be my life's duty to bear the weight," I tell him. "This is truly my last decision."

The laws of this world straighten themselves in the absence of my thread. I can feel my form crumbling to dead Essence, returning to the place I've belonged since the beginning. I only pray she's waiting for me there on the other side.

Ullrich slips from my grasp, and the ground trembles at the sudden dissipation of pure Essence. Below us, a dark chasm has no bottom.

"I'm going back. I'll unwrite this, Fletcher. As many times as it takes to save you. To save our people. Our family. Our—"

He goes limp: brain-dead from an infinity of unlikely events that unfolds in the next seven seconds.

He swells with layers upon layers of threads faster than I can blink, and when he falls backwards, the back of his coat snares on a sharp stone edge, damping his fall.

His limp body cascades into the pit, still living. I watch as the perfect combination of twelve rocks, lined end-to-end, fall to form an arched platform for him to land on, and he lands hard.

I feel Sylvia grab me from behind as I lose my presence in this life, and she turns me, only to find that she's dissolving, too.

"We were both never meant to be here," I tell her. "We've both long overstayed our welcome."

"I enjoyed every second of it with you," she says, and when I hold her closer, I can feel our Essence coalesce in a single stream.

The last sensation I feel is our abrasive lips pressing together. Consciousness dissolves into something blank and formless, changing from a person into no more than an idea.